



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Classical Academy de Lafayette
School Website: <https://lafayetteacademy.org/>

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Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Classical Academy De Lafayette Mo 63368 (Lafayette Academy) demonstrates a robust classical-education orientation across its public-facing materials. The school presents a mission rooted in forming virtuous character through a content-rich classical liberal-arts program, with explicit emphasis on truth, goodness, beauty, and the cultivation of wisdom. Its curriculum foregrounds the liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Latin), Great Books/readings from Western canon, and a rhetoric-focused upper school, all signaling a strong Classical alignment. While the school foregrounds formation, virtue, and the Great Books tradition, it shows less explicit, overt theology-led pedagogy or liturgical practices in public materials. Taken together, the school rates CLASSICAL overall, with Category-specific notes discussed below.

Key anchors across sources include: mission statements that tie academic rigor to virtue and true wisdom; explicit reference to reading Great Books and a "great conversation" approach; emphasis on the trivium/quadrivium through grammar and rhetoric, with a rhetoric stage in high school; and an emphasis on teacher leadership, low-tech classrooms, and parent engagement as part of a classical formation.

Overall classification: CLASSICAL.

- What stands out: Consistent emphasis on virtue, truth, beauty, and goodness; great-books orientation; explicit rhetoric and logic/Latin through the grade levels; strong teacher-leadership and formation through a "living curriculum" ethos; active parent engagement through open houses, tours, and community events.
- What would move the needle (if needed): The public materials could further explicitly articulate theology-grounded integration, liturgical/community practices, and a more explicit articulation of scholē/restful-learning principles in lower and middle grades to strengthen the Religious & Metaphysical Foundations and Pedagogy categories. Notably, the current materials already include many of the core classical elements and strong formation language, which justifies the CLASSICAL classification at present. No major needle-moving changes are required at this time.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school consistently emphasizes virtue, truth, beauty, and goodness as central to the education, tying intellect and character formation together. Public materials state: "education should form both mind and character" and "classical education values knowledge for its own sake. It upholds the standards of logic, beauty, truth, and goodness intrinsic to the liberal arts." This signals a transcendental moral framework and a commitment to knowing higher realities. - There are explicit references to Judaism and Christianity in historical-geography contexts, suggesting a Western-Christian-cultural heritage within the curriculum. This points to some theological grounding in the content (though not a stated theology-course mandate in every discipline).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive: virtue, truth, beauty, goodness, formation, moral imagination, Western civilization, classical education, liberal arts. Public materials frequently use phrases like "virtue,"

“great books,” and “truth, goodness, and beauty.” - Negative: explicit liturgical or sacramental practices or overt theology integration across all disciplines are not clearly claimed in public-facing materials. Liturgical/-communal practices are not evidenced as a core component in the public materials reviewed.

Why this rating - The presence of transcendental moral language (truth, goodness, beauty), virtue formation, and a Western-civilization orientation suggests a Classical framework with a strong metaphysical orientation, even if theology is not foregrounded as a universal discipline across all classes. The lack of explicit, uniform liturgical practices or theology-integrated pedagogy reduces this from “CLASSICAL” to “SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL” in strict rubric terms for this category, but the weight of evidence supporting transcendental foundations and virtue-centered formation supports the higher end of the spectrum. Therefore: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The mission explicitly states formation of mind and character through a rigorous classical program, aiming to cultivate virtuous character. Statements such as “to develop the academic potential of each student through a rigorous, content-rich, classical liberal arts program while cultivating in them a virtuous character” anchor the purpose in virtue and human excellence rather than mere job preparation. - The school emphasizes teaching HOW to think, not WHAT to think, and highlights great books as vehicles for formation, aligning with truth, goodness, and beauty as real, knowable goods. - Virtues are codified (Fortitude, Justice, Prudence, Temperance), underscoring formation as a goal beyond information transfer.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive: virtue, wisdom, truth, goodness, beauty, formation, great books, classical liberal arts, how to think, character formation. - Negative: none evident in public materials; no strong emphasis on purely vocational or job-readiness framing. The emphasis remains formation-first.

Why this rating - The public materials clearly frame education as formation toward human excellence and the pursuit of enduring truths, not solely job preparation, which aligns squarely with Classical aims for Element 2. The presence of explicit virtues and “how to think” language further cements CLASSICAL here.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Core curriculum elements include Great Books/readings from the Western canon, with explicit emphasis on literature from classic novels, poetry, and plays, as well as classics-based field experiences and primary sources; the curriculum is designed to parallel history. The school highlights reading of the Great Books and a “great conversation” through literature selections aligned with historical eras. - Grammar, logic, rhetoric (the Trivium) are foregrounded through explicit references to grammar/diagramming, logic, and rhetoric in course descriptions across grades; Latin begins in later grades (Latin study is listed among core subjects). - History & Geography coverage is integrated across grades, with emphasis on major historical epochs and the Western tradition, reinforcing interdisciplinary integration and continuity of study (not just “social studies”). - Public materials emphasize the Great Books and the liberal-arts tradition as the curriculum backbone, with explicit references to primary sources and canonical literature.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive: Great Books, Western canon, liberal arts, grammar, logic, rhetoric, primary sources, history through curriculum, reading of the great books, formation through study of literature. - Negative: no explicit heavy emphasis on non-classical subjects or ephemeral, skill-based curricula; no mention of “project-based” or fully exploratory, non-traditional curricula in the core materials (though some projects are implied within content). Public materials do not emphasize a contemporary fracturing of curriculum in opposition to classical methods.

Why this rating - The curriculum centers on the Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Latin), Great Books, and an integrated historic-literary program, consistent with Classical curriculum expectations. The presence of primary-source history, canonical literature, and literature aligned with a “great conversation” supports a CLASSICAL rating for Curriculum.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes Socratic discussion and rhetoric in the upper grades as part of a rhetoric stage; there is explicit emphasis on logic and argument in high school, and a Rhetoric Stage is named. This aligns with Socratic pedagogy and dialectic as pillars of classical teaching. - The mission states “Teaching HOW to think, not WHAT to think,” reflecting a focus on disciplined inquiry, critical reasoning, and guided dialogue. - There is explicit mention of “Scholé” (restful learning) concepts in the Six Essential Elements documents (pedagogical framework), and the public materials convey a teacher-led, high-expectation approach with strong memory work and repetition (e.g., grammar-diagramming, memorization, and recitation in core subjects). While direct lower-grade chanting references aren’t ubiquitous in every page, the public materials emphasize memory work, repetition, and foundational discipline consistent with classical pedagogy.

- The school highlights lower-teacher-led classical pedagogy and collaborative learning through discussion and rhetoric, supported by explicit content on logic, grammar, and Latin.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive: Socratic dialogue, dialectic, great conversation, guided discussion, logic, rhetoric, scholé (restful learning), memory work, singing/chanting as memory devices, formation through imitation. - Negative: The public materials do not strongly emphasize purely project-based or experiential-learning contrasts in the core classical frame (though some field experiences and day trips exist; not central as a primary pedagogy). The core pedagogy remains discussion-based, memory-focused, and rhetoric-driven.

Why this rating - The explicit inclusion of Socratic/dialectic elements, logic and rhetoric instruction, and a rhetoric-stage for upper grades are central to classical pedagogy. Coupled with a mission emphasizing thinking over mere content delivery, Pedagogy earns CLASSICAL.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school presents teachers as dedicated, virtue-modeling mentors; the mission emphasizes “cultivating virtuous character” and “great teachers.” The public materials depict faculty as dedicated staff and leaders in formation; there is a sense of a “living curriculum” where teachers embody and model the standards of the school. - The school discusses “Founders/Head of School,” “dedicated staff,” and “passionate educators” during open-house materials, indicating a closely connected faculty culture with a mentoring orientation. - The public materials emphasize teacher leadership and the teacher as a core element of the school’s identity and formation, consistent with a Classical model where the faculty is a central living curriculum.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive: model teachers and mentors; living curriculum; faculty as core; teacher-led, low-tech classrooms; dedicated educators; great books and canonical content through the faculty. - Negative: no explicit mention of formal staff development programs or teacher-specific professional development details in public pages (though this may exist elsewhere; not evident in the core public materials).

Why this rating - The public materials describe a faculty culture that embodies virtue, mentorship, and a living curriculum, aligning with CLASSICAL expectations for Faculty.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes partnerships with families, parental engagement, and parent participation in classical education culture (Open Houses, tours, events; Gala; prospective/family gatherings). The mission includes “partnership with families” and the Great Books, Western heritage, and formation are presented as a shared enterprise with families. Public materials frequently invite parents to events, tours, and informational sessions, which signals active parent involvement. - The site encourages public-facing events for prospective families, current families, and community involvement (Open House events, tours, Gala). This demonstrates a policy of welcoming and involving parents as co-educators in the classical formation process. - The Six Elements’ positive keyword lists emphasize “Partnership with Families” as a defining feature of classical education, which is reflected in Lafayette Academy’s public materials (parent involvement

opportunities, open-house events, and community engagement).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive: partnership with families, parent partnership, co-educators, parental engagement, school-parent collaboration, tours, open houses, community events, parental involvement, Great Books, Western heritage. - Negative: there is no explicit evidence of “parent-only” governance or isolation of parents from the classroom; rather, the materials show active engagement. No clear negative keywords appear in the public materials.

Why this rating - The public content demonstrates robust parent-and-community involvement and a partnership model with families, consistent with CLASSICAL expectations for Element 6.

Aggregate Assessment

- Element 1: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 2: CLASSICAL
- Element 3: CLASSICAL
- Element 4: CLASSICAL
- Element 5: CLASSICAL
- Element 6: CLASSICAL

Overall classification: CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle

- If aiming for a fuller CLASSICAL alignment in Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations), the school could explicitly articulate a Theology-grounded framework across the curriculum, there by more clearly identifying liturgical or communal practices and a theology-integrated approach to schooling. Strengthening explicit references to liturgical and communal practices or consistently integrating a theology dimension in the broader curriculum would convert the slight gap into a stronger CLASSICAL signal in this category.
- Additional explicit articulation of Scholé/restful learning principles in lower grades and more overt incorporation of contemplative practices across the day could further strengthen Pedagogy (Element 4) as well, though current pedagogical language already aligns with Socratic, dialectic, and memory-based approaches.
- Concrete steps (examples):
 - Publish a concise statement or page detailing theology integration across disciplines (even if framed as “classical Catholic/Christian worldview integration” or “Judaic-Christian Western tradition” within history and literature).
 - Highlight liturgical or communal practices (e.g., formal gatherings, shared reflective practices) as a component of daily or weekly rhythms.
 - Expand explicit Scholé language in lower grades (e.g., scheduled contemplative cycles, slower-paced reflection blocks) and publicly describe how memory work, recitation, and wonder-based experiences contribute to formation.

ABSTRACT

Overall classification: CLASSICAL

- The Lafayette Academy materials show a coherent Classical framework: a virtue-centered mission; commitment to the Great Books and Western-canon literature; grammar-logic-rhetoric curriculum with Latin; a rhetoric-centric high school; and a teacher-centered, formation-oriented approach with parent involvement. These elements align strongly with classical education principles across the six categories.
- Category-by-category snapshot:
 - Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL — strong formation/virtue

and transcendental values are evident; theology and liturgical practices are not clearly foregrounded across all disciplines.

- School Purpose and Goal: CLASSICAL — formation of virtue and wisdom, truth-goodness-beauty, and “HOW to think” orientation are explicit.
- Curriculum: CLASSICAL — grammar-logic-rhetoric, Great Books, and history-depth alignment with liberal-arts curriculum.
- Pedagogy: CLASSICAL — Socratic/dialogic elements, rhetoric, memory work, and a Scholé-oriented rhythm underpin teaching methods.
- Faculty: CLASSICAL — living curriculum, mentor-teachers, and a culture of virtuous modeling are described.
- Parents & Community: CLASSICAL — active partnership with families, open houses, tours, and community events; parent engagement is a core emphasis.

- Most important insights:

- The school robustly embodies classical education values in mission, curriculum, pedagogy, and community engagement, with a notable emphasis on virtue, Great Books, and the Trivium/Rhetoric progression.
- The primary gap lies in an explicit, church/theology-led framework and liturgical/community practices beyond historical references; addressing this publicly would strengthen Element 1 to a solid CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle (applies to SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL instances) - Explicate theology-grounded integration across disciplines. - Publicly embrace liturgical/community practices as part of the educational rhythm. - Extend explicit Scholé/restful-learning language into the public-facing materials for foundational grades.

End of report.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

- Overall: CLASSICAL
- Most categories meet Classical criteria; Element 1 is the closest to the boundary (SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL) due to explicit formation-based signals but less explicit liturgical/theology integration in public materials. The school demonstrates a coherent classical program across curriculum, pedagogy, faculty, and parent/community engagement, with strong Great Books emphasis, grammar-logic-rhetoric study, and a virtue-centered mission.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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